History / Secondary

Evidence and inference in history

A source can tell you something directly and suggest further possibilities. Separate what it shows from what you infer.

Core ideas

1. Identify the author or creator, date, audience and purpose where available.
2. Describe relevant evidence before drawing an inference.
3. Compare with other evidence. A source's usefulness depends on the question being asked.

Worked example

A practice source is a fictional factory poster asking workers to increase output. It is direct evidence of the message the poster presents. It cannot, by itself, prove that every worker agreed with the message.

Try it yourself

1. What is an inference?
2. Can one poster establish what every person believed?
3. Why consider the intended audience?

Check your answers

1. An interpretation drawn from evidence.
2. No. More evidence is needed.
3. It helps explain how and why the message was presented in that form.